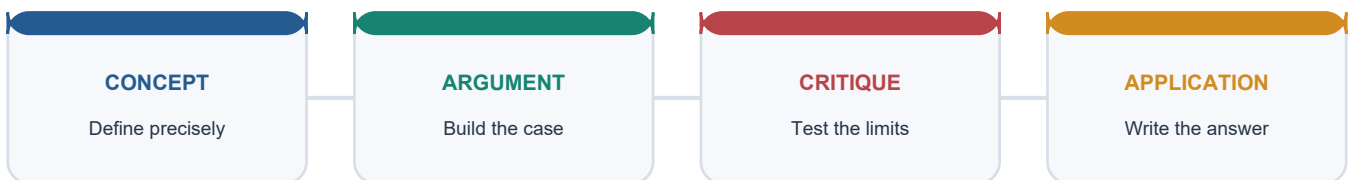


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion 04 - Soul: Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper II, Section B | 32 diagnostics, 17 solved PYQs and 6 original Mains models

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion 04 - Soul: Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation - Solved Practice Workbook

Standalone workbook. It reproduces the complete practice apparatus of the Soul, Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation learning package and can be worked without the teaching sessions. Syllabus, verbatim: *Soul : Immortality; Rebirth and Liberation*. - UPSC Philosophy Paper II, Philosophy of Religion, item 4. □ Full Indian-school self-metaphysics belongs to the Paper I owners, revelation and faith-based warrant to Reason, Revelation and Faith, the phenomenology of religious experience to Religious Experience, karma as an answer to suffering to Problem of Evil, and the complete case for a non-creator religion to Religion without God; they appear here only where a premise of this clause requires them. **Evidence discipline:** FACT: doctrine on which the standard sources converge · ANALYSIS: analytical reconstruction for exam use · CAUTION: a live scholarly dispute. Model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys; UPSC publishes no descriptive model answer for Philosophy Paper II, and Philosophy Optional is examined only at the Mains stage, so no objective question here is a previous-year question. **Terminology rule:** the English concept leads and the technical term follows immediately in parentheses - *self (ātman)*, *individual soul (jīva)*, *no permanent self (anātman; Pali: anattā)*, *dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda)*, *re-becoming (punarbhava)*, *rebirth (punarjanma)*, *wandering-on (saṃsāra)*, *release (mokṣa)*, *final cessation of pain (apavarga)*, *aloneness (kaivalya)*, *extinguishing (nirvāṇa)*, *liberation while living (jīvanmukti)*, *liberation at the fall of the body (videhamukti)*, *already-fructifying karma (prārabdha)*, *unseen moral potency (adrṣṭa/apūrva)*, *subtle body (sūkṣma-śarīra)*, *latent dispositions (saṃskāra/vāsanā)*, *inflow of karmic matter (āśrava)*, *bondage (bandha)*, *stoppage (saṃvara)*, *shedding (nirjarā)*, *omniscience (kevala-jñāna)*, *devotion (bhakti)*, *self-surrender (prapatti)*, *discriminative discernment (viveka-khyāti)*. Provenance is examinable: Plato, *Phaedo*; *Bhagavad Gītā* 2.22, 2.23, 5.4-5, 9.21, 9.32, 18.66; *Bhāgavata Purāṇa* 7.5.23; *Sāṃkhya-kārikā* 1, 62-63, 67-68; *Yoga-sūtra* 1.2, 1.3, 1.24, 2.3, 4.29, 4.34; Oscar Cullmann, *Immortality of the Soul or Resurrection of the Dead?* (1955); John Hick, *Philosophy of Religion* and *Death and Eternal Life*; Peter van Inwagen on the possibility of resurrection; Aquinas on the soul as form; Kant's paralogisms. CAUTION: The ascription of the *Vivekacūḍāmaṇi* to Śaṅkara is disputed. No page, edition or invented quotation is attached to any of them.

What this workbook contains

Component	Count
Original diagnostic MCQs - 24 core plus 8 remedial drills	32
Question-specific option explanations	128
Unique examiner traps	32
Directly owned verified PYQs solved in full, 2018-2025	17
Original solved Mains models - two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks	6

How to use it

1. Attempt the twenty-four core MCQs without notes, then read every option explanation, including those for the options you rejected. The key sequence is **unpatterned** - each answer was fixed independently - so no cycle can be guessed, and option lengths are matched so the answer cannot be spotted by shape.
2. Work the eight remedial drills only after the core set. They target the confluences that cost marks on this clause every year: resurrection assimilated to rebirth, *nāstika* mistranslated as atheist, detachability overstated into a disproof of theism, two-obligation stems half answered, no-self read as no-continuity, *apavarga* described as bliss, liberating knowledge made to destroy already-fructifying karma, and Sāṃkhya aloneness confused with Jain omniscience.
3. Attempt each previous-year part under time before reading its solution. **Decide the demanded structure from the directive first:** four parts are modal necessity questions, four name a specific liberation term, three impose two obligations in one stem, two demand evaluation of a pathway or a postulate, one is an enumeration of three

doctrines, and one is a plausibility grading.

4. Write the six original models in full. Two are 10-mark, two 15-mark and two 20-mark, and each sits inside the declared word band - **10 marks about 150 words, 15 marks about 250 words, 20 marks about 300 words.**
5. Check every answer against the four control questions of this clause: which survival term is in play, what the continuity-bearer is, which liberation terminus is meant, and whether the verdict is stated as *necessary*, *sufficient* or *neither*. A script that answers only the first has left most of the marks on the table.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Philosophy Optional is examined only at the Mains stage, so **no question below is a Prelims previous-year question**. All thirty-two are original UPSC-style diagnostics written against this owner's doctrine.

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed **independently**, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated and no cycle such as ABCD - or its reverse - can be used to guess. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

Coverage: the twenty-four core questions run across the whole printed clause - *Soul : Immortality; Rebirth and Liberation* - covering the six survival terms and the modal question, the models of the person and the four identity criteria, Hick's replica and the duplication objection, Plato's four arguments with Simmias and Kant, the five argument families and body/brain dependence, Hindu immortality with its verse base and school differences, karma as act-plus-potency with the threefold ledger and the superintendent question, rebirth as the widened field of maturation, the Buddhist argument with its illustrations and the responsibility objection, the seven-destination parity bench, Advaita and Viśiṣṭādvaita with embodied liberation and the real-agent question, the Jain inflow-to-shedding ladder, Nyāya cessation and Sāṃkhya-Yoga aloneness, devotion with the grace-effort dispute, the three-means disagreement, and the resurrection comparator. The eight remedial drills attack the conflationations that cost marks on this clause every year.

MCQ 1. Which survival term the stem is actually using

A stem asks whether the anti-theistic traditions can consistently maintain "rebirth". Which preliminary move earns the first marks and controls the rest of the answer?

- A. Establishing at once that rebirth, reincarnation and resurrection name a single doctrine that different religious cultures happen to express in different idioms.
- B. Establishing that the question must be about heaven, since any post-mortem continuation of a person is by definition a religious reward for merit.
- C. Establishing that rebirth is the wider term and that reincarnation, which presupposes a substantial soul re-entering flesh, is only one reading of it.
- D. Establishing that the term is too vague for philosophical use, so the answer should replace it with the neutral vocabulary of psychological continuity.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the terms differ in number of lives, mechanism, judge and identity-bearer, and merging them is the standing error this clause is designed to detect.
- **B:** Incorrect: the *Bhagavad Gītā* at 9.21 returns the meritorious to the world of mortals, so heaven is a stage inside the wandering-on rather than its terminus.
- **C:** Correct: reincarnation carries a substantialist commitment that Buddhism refuses, so only the wider term "rebirth" covers re-becoming (*punarbhava*) as well.
- **D:** Incorrect: the vocabulary is precise once the terms are separated, and abandoning it would discard the very distinction the examiner is testing.

Examiner trap 1: Candidates open with a definition of the soul; the examiner awards the opening marks to whoever separates the six survival terms in the first two lines instead.

MCQ 2. The modal shape of the necessity question

"Immortality of the soul is a necessary postulate for rebirth." Which verdict states the position defended by this owner most exactly?

- A. It is necessary and sufficient, because every school that accepts rebirth also accepts a deathless soul that carries the moral residue forward.
- B. It is neither necessary nor sufficient, because rebirth is a cultural doctrine that stands entirely independent of any claim about what persists.
- C. It is necessary but not sufficient, because a deathless soul is required for rebirth but karmic desert must be added before re-embodiment follows.
- D. It is sufficient but not necessary, because a persisting soul would guarantee rebirth while Buddhism secures re-becoming through causal continuity alone.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Buddhism affirms re-becoming (*punarbhava*) while denying a permanent self, and one working counter-example is enough to defeat a necessity claim.
- **B:** Incorrect: rebirth is not independent of continuity; it requires a continuity-bearer, and the schools dispute only whether that bearer must be a substance.
- **C:** Incorrect: this inverts the verdict, since the Buddhist case shows precisely that the soul-condition is dispensable rather than indispensable.
- **D:** Correct: sufficiency is granted to the substantialist systems while the Buddhist counter-example defeats necessity, which is the modal claim the examiner buys.

Examiner trap 2: A script that surveys school opinions without ever writing the words "necessary" or "sufficient" has answered a different question from the one set.

MCQ 3. What the identity criteria are severally for

Which statement about the four criteria of personal identity is correct as this owner presents them?

- A. Bodily and psychological criteria tell us how identity is recognised, while soul-substance and causal continuity are proposals about what constitutes it.
- B. Memory is the definition of personal identity, so any account of survival that cannot deliver recollection of a previous life is thereby refuted outright.
- C. The bodily criterion is decisive in every case, so resurrection succeeds as a theory of survival while rebirth necessarily fails as a theory of survival.
- D. The four criteria are rival answers to one question, so exactly one of them must be correct and the philosophical task is to eliminate the other three.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the first pair answers how we tell and the second answers what makes it so, and noticing the difference is what lifts a script into the top band.
- **B:** Incorrect: memory presupposes identity rather than defining it, and forgetfulness within one life already shows it to be a poor criterion.
- **C:** Incorrect: bodily continuity fails outright at death, which is why resurrection accounts must invoke form, preservation or replica rather than the body alone.
- **D:** Incorrect: the criteria answer different questions, so treating them as exclusive rivals mistakes a division of labour for a contradiction.

Examiner trap 3: Treating memory as the definition of identity turns the memory objection to rebirth into a refutation, when the owner treats it only as a pressure.

MCQ 4. Hick's replica and what the duplication objection shows

Hick's replica thought experiment is best described, together with its standard objection, as which of the following?

- A. A proof that souls are naturally immortal, undermined by the fact that no replica has ever been observed to appear in any resurrection world.
- B. A description of Indian rebirth in Western vocabulary, undermined by the absence of karmic conditioning in the way the replica is produced.
- C. A defence of the coherence of resurrection identity, undermined by the point that if God can make one replica he can make two, which identity forbids.
- D. An argument that memory is unnecessary for survival, undermined by the fact that the replica is stipulated to possess complete memory and character.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the experiment defends resurrection identity, and it is expressly not an argument for a naturally deathless soul in the Platonic sense.
- **B:** Incorrect: the replica addresses divine re-constitution of an embodied person, which is structurally different from karmically conditioned re-embodiment.
- **C:** Correct: Hick restricts the case to a unique replica, and critics answer that the bare possibility of duplication shows the criterion tracks similarity.
- **D:** Incorrect: memory continuity is central to the case rather than dispensable, and the objection concerns numerical identity rather than memory.

Examiner trap 4: Presenting the replica as evidence for survival converts a coherence argument into an evidential one and invites the objection that no such case is observed.

MCQ 5. What the recollection argument actually establishes

In the *Phaedo*, the argument from recollection (*anamnesis*), taken by itself, establishes which conclusion?

- A. That the soul existed before embodiment, since the standard by which sensible things are judged deficient is not supplied by sense-experience.
- B. That the soul survives the death of the body, since knowledge once acquired by a simple substance cannot afterwards be destroyed by decomposition.
- C. That the soul is immaterial and simple, since only a partless subject could retain a standard of comparison through a change of embodiment.
- D. That learning is impossible without teaching, since a standard of equality must be transmitted to the soul by instruction from another knower.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: recollection infers pre-existence from our grasp of a standard that deficient sensible instances cannot supply, and it establishes only that direction.
- **B:** Incorrect: survival is a separate conclusion, which is why Plato pairs recollection with the cyclical argument to close the post-mortem direction too.
- **C:** Incorrect: simplicity belongs to the affinity argument, which reasons from the soul's likeness to invisible and stable reality rather than from learning.
- **D:** Incorrect: the argument's point is the opposite, namely that instruction elicits what the soul already possesses rather than transmitting it afresh.

Examiner trap 5: Letting recollection do the work of survival collapses two of Plato's four arguments and forfeits the marks reserved for assessing each separately.

MCQ 6. The final argument and its weak joint

Plato's final argument holds that the soul, essentially bringing Life, cannot admit death. Which criticism identifies the argument's real weak point?

- A. That fire and snow are inanimate, so no analogy drawn from them can establish anything at all about a subject that is by nature living.
- B. That Forms cannot be brought by anything, since participation runs in the opposite direction, from particulars upward to the Forms they resemble.
- C. That the soul does not bring Life but merely accompanies it, so the essential predication on which the whole argument depends is simply false.
- D. That "cannot admit death" secures only that a soul cannot be a dead soul, and a further step is needed to show that it cannot simply cease to exist.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the analogy is used to display essential predication, and its inanimacy is irrelevant to whether that pattern of reasoning transfers.
- **B:** Incorrect: the argument's participation language is standard in the dialogue, and rejecting it wholesale attacks Platonism rather than this argument.
- **C:** Incorrect: this simply denies the premise without argument, whereas the recognised difficulty concerns the inference drawn from that premise.
- **D:** Correct: fire does not become cold, yet fire goes out, so exclusion of the contrary does not by itself yield indestructibility.

Examiner trap 6: Scripts summarise the four arguments as one proof; "critically examine" demands four separate assessments, each with the objection that fits it.

MCQ 7. Simmias, Kant, and the two kinds of criticism

Which pairing correctly matches each critic to the criticism this owner attributes to him?

- A. Simmias holds that the soul is a knowable substance, while Kant holds that the soul is an attunement whose existence depends on bodily elements.
- B. Simmias holds that recollection is circular, while Kant holds that the cyclical argument confuses qualitative opposites with existence and non-existence.
- C. Simmias holds that the soul is an attunement of the body, while Kant holds that the unity of consciousness is not knowledge of a persisting substance.
- D. Simmias holds that immortality is a postulate of practical reason, while Kant holds that the soul rules the body and therefore cannot be its harmony.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the two positions are swapped, and Kant's paralogism argues precisely that the soul is *not* a knowable substance.
- **B:** Incorrect: neither criticism is stated in these terms, and the difficulty about qualitative opposites belongs to the assessment of the cyclical argument.
- **C:** Correct: the harmony objection is Simmias' in the same dialogue, and Kant's paralogism denies that formal unity of apperception yields a substance.
- **D:** Incorrect: the postulate belongs to Kant's practical philosophy, and the rule-over-the-body point is Plato's reply to Simmias rather than Kant's thesis.

Examiner trap 7: Omitting Simmias loses the objection Plato himself answers inside the *Phaedo*, which examiners treat as the test of whether the dialogue was read.

MCQ 8. What body/brain dependence does to the debate

The systematic dependence of memory, personality and agency on bodily conditions has which effect on the survival debate, as this owner states it?

- A. It shifts the burden onto the survivalist to supply accounts of interaction, individuation and identity, without deductively proving that no subject survives.
- B. It deductively refutes every theory of survival, since a mind that depends on a brain cannot by definition continue when that brain has ceased to function.
- C. It leaves the debate untouched, since dependence during embodied life is fully compatible with, and gives no evidence about, any post-mortem condition.
- D. It establishes the hylomorphic account, since only a soul that is the form of a living body can explain why mental life varies with cerebral states.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the owner treats the objection as burden-shifting rather than demonstrative, and lists exactly those three debts the survivalist then owes.
- **B:** Incorrect: dependence during embodiment does not entail impossibility afterwards, and stating it as a refutation overreaches the evidence.
- **C:** Incorrect: this understates the objection, since a systematic dependence is evidentially relevant even where it is not conclusive.
- **D:** Incorrect: hylomorphism is one response among several, and the dependence data underdetermine the choice between the available models of the person.

Examiner trap 8: Treating brain-dependence as a disproof produces an unbalanced answer that cannot then explain why the survival debate continues at all.

MCQ 9. The verse base of Hindu immortality

Which mapping of *Bhagavad Gītā* references to their exam use is correct?

- A. 2.22 for indestructibility, 2.23 for the exhaustion of merit, and 9.21 for the discarding of worn-out garments at the moment of re-embodiment.
- B. 2.22 for the discarding of worn-out garments, 2.23 for indestructibility by weapons and elements, and 9.21 for return when merit is exhausted.
- C. 2.22 for the convergence of knowledge and action, 2.23 for the nine limbs of devotion, and 9.21 for the final instruction to take refuge alone.
- D. 2.22 for the injunction to desireless action, 2.23 for the plurality of pure consciousnesses, and 9.21 for the definition of embodied liberation.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the first two references are interchanged, and 9.21 concerns return from the heavenly world rather than the change of garments.
- **B:** Correct: garments at 2.22, indestructibility at 2.23, and return on the exhaustion of merit at 9.21 is the owner's verified mapping.
- **C:** Incorrect: convergence belongs to 5.4-5, the nine limbs to *Bhāgavata Purāṇa* 7.5.23, and the refuge verse to 18.66.
- **D:** Incorrect: none of these attributions is correct, and the plurality of consciousnesses belongs to Sāṃkhya rather than to any *Gītā* verse.

Examiner trap 9: A stem that says "with reference to the *Bhagavad Gītā*" is testing verse fidelity, and generic Vedānta without citation will not satisfy the directive.

MCQ 10. Where freedom operates in the threefold karma ledger

Given the classification of karma into stored (*sañcita*), already-fructifying (*prārabdha*) and future (*āgāmi*), where does present effort operate?

- A. On already-fructifying karma alone, since only what is currently maturing is close enough to present action to be altered by any effort at all.
- B. On none of the three, since the classification is precisely what shows karma to be a doctrine of fate in which present effort can change nothing.
- C. On future karma directly and on stored karma through liberating knowledge, but never on the portion that has already begun to fructify in this life.
- D. On stored karma alone, since the accumulated store is the only portion that has not yet been assigned to a particular embodiment or lifespan.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: fructifying karma is precisely the portion that runs its course, which is why the embodiment of a liberated knower continues at all.
- **B:** Incorrect: the classification exists to defeat the fatalist reading by locating exactly where effort still has purchase.
- **C:** Correct: effort generates and shapes future karma, liberating knowledge destroys the stored portion, and the fructifying portion is untouched.
- **D:** Incorrect: this ignores future karma, which is the portion present action is generating at every moment.

Examiner trap 10: Saying that liberating knowledge destroys all karma makes embodied liberation unintelligible and contradicts the potter's-wheel image the tradition uses.

MCQ 11. Who administers the law of karma

Which statement correctly represents the division between theistic and non-theistic accounts of karmic administration?

- A. Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā treat the law as self-regulating, while Nyāya and the theistic Vedāntas make God the superintendent who dispenses the fruits.
- B. All Indian schools require a divine judge, since an impersonal law could not by itself match a particular fruit to a particular agent at a particular time.
- C. Only Advaita dispenses with a judge, since its non-dualism leaves no room for a distinct divine person capable of allocating results to individuals.
- D. Buddhism requires a judge but conceals the fact, while Jainism and Mīmāṃsā openly assign the administrative role to a creator who oversees the whole series.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: this is the owner's fork, with the theistic schools making God the ratifier of desert rather than its author.
- **B:** Incorrect: the anti-theistic schools explicitly deny any judge, and their doing so is precisely what makes their position philosophically significant.
- **C:** Incorrect: the self-regulating accounts are the Buddhist, Jain and Mīmāṃsā ones, and Advaita is not the school that defines this contrast.
- **D:** Incorrect: Buddhism has no divine judge at all, and Jainism explicitly has no creator God administering the karmic process.

Examiner trap 11: Making God the author of desert rather than its superintendent turns a Nyāya answer into a theodicy and misstates the school's own position.

MCQ 12. What rebirth contributes to karma theory

A 15-mark stem asks for the *significance* of rebirth in the theory of karma. Which formulation answers the question asked?

- A. Rebirth describes the passage of the subtle body from one embodiment to another, carrying the mind, the senses and the vital breath across the interval.
- B. Rebirth is a devotional teaching whose function is consolatory, offering the bereaved the assurance that a further meeting is possible in a later life.
- C. Rebirth is a cosmological doctrine about the cyclical structure of time, which the karmic law then borrows in order to describe the fate of individuals.
- D. Rebirth widens the temporal field in which karmic consequences mature, which is what allows the moral law to remain exceptionless without being visibly false.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this describes the mechanism when the stem asks for the function, and description is the standard way marks are lost on this question.
- **B:** Incorrect: consolation is not the philosophical role assigned by the owner, and treating it as such abandons the argumentative reading.
- **C:** Incorrect: the direction of dependence is reversed, since rebirth is required by the karmic claim rather than borrowed from cosmology.
- **D:** Correct: rebirth is the exit that preserves an exceptionless law against the evident fact that many acts do not mature within one lifetime.

Examiner trap 12: Describing rebirth when the stem asks for its significance converts an analytic question into a narrative one and caps the script well below the top band.

MCQ 13. The Buddhist argument, step by step

Which sequence states the Buddhist route from impermanence to rebirth without a permanent self?

- A. All aggregates are permanent; the self is one of them; craving is therefore eternal; and rebirth follows as the eternal self takes successive bodies.
- B. All conditioned factors are impermanent; no aggregate is a self; craving and karmic formations condition future consciousness; so continuity occurs without an owner.
- C. All conditioned factors are impermanent; the self is therefore unknowable; rebirth is accordingly a conventional fiction; and moral responsibility is abandoned.
- D. All aggregates are momentary; a permanent self is inferred to explain their unity; and rebirth is that self's passage from one aggregate-series to the next.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the first premise is reversed, and the conclusion reinstates the very transmigrating self the doctrine of no-self denies.
- **B:** Correct: these are the owner's four steps, and they yield continuity through conditioning rather than through a persisting substance.
- **C:** Incorrect: rebirth is affirmed rather than treated as a fiction, and moral responsibility is retained on the basis of causal descent.
- **D:** Incorrect: no permanent self is inferred; the unity of experience is explained by conditioning among the aggregates themselves.

Examiner trap 13: Writing that Buddhism "denies continuity" misstates the doctrine; what is denied is a permanent, independent substance-self, not the conditioned stream.

MCQ 14. Who receives the fruit if nothing persists

The objection that no one remains to receive the karmic fruit is answered by the Buddhist tradition in which way, and with what residue?

- A. By denying that karmic fruit exists at all, with the residue that the tradition's extensive teaching on merit and demerit becomes wholly unintelligible.
- B. By invoking a subtle body that carries dispositions, with the residue that the doctrine of no-self is quietly abandoned at the point where it matters most.
- C. By appealing to divine record-keeping, with the residue that a creator is reintroduced into a system whose whole interest lies in dispensing with one.
- D. By locating responsibility in causal descent rather than substantial identity, with the residue that critics doubt descent alone makes the fruit genuinely one's own.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: karmic consequence is affirmed throughout, and denying it would dissolve the moral teaching the doctrine is designed to support.
- **B:** Incorrect: the subtle-body vehicle belongs to the Vedāntic and Sāṃkhya accounts rather than to the Buddhist explanation of continuity.
- **C:** Incorrect: no divine record-keeper is invoked, and the absence of one is part of what makes the position philosophically distinctive.
- **D:** Correct: the reply is the "neither the same nor wholly other" formula, and the owner records the ownership worry as a genuine remaining pressure.

Examiner trap 14: Reporting the doctrine without meeting the "who is reborn?" objection reads as evasion, and examiners withhold the evaluative marks accordingly.

MCQ 15. The one liberation without consciousness

On the parity bench of liberation-termini, which school's terminus is characterised by the absence of consciousness itself?

- A. Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, whose *apavarga* ends pain together with the qualities that sustain experience, consciousness being adventitious to the self-substance.
- B. Sāṃkhya-Yoga, whose *kaivalya* is the aloneness of a witness that has never possessed consciousness and acquires none at the moment of discrimination.
- C. Advaita Vedānta, whose *mokṣa* extinguishes the individual knower, leaving an impersonal ground in which no awareness of any kind can be present.
- D. Jainism, whose liberated soul sheds karmic matter and with it the four infinitudes, since perfection consists in the absence of all determinate qualities.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Nyāya treats consciousness as adventitious, arising only on conjunction with mind, senses and body, so release leaves the substance without it.
- **B:** Incorrect: *puruṣa* is pure consciousness by nature; what *kaivalya* removes is content and association, never awareness itself.
- **C:** Incorrect: Advaitic release is self-luminous and non-dual, and describing it as unconscious inverts the school's central claim.
- **D:** Incorrect: the four infinitudes - knowledge, perception, bliss and energy - are manifested at liberation rather than shed with the karmic matter.

Examiner trap 15: Describing *apavarga* as blissful is the most frequent error on the 2024 stem, and it contradicts the Nyāya account of consciousness outright.

MCQ 16. One syllable, two opposite contents

The terms *kaivalya* in Sāṃkhya-Yoga and *kevala-jñāna* in Jainism stand in which relation?

- A. They are synonyms drawn from a shared classical vocabulary, both denoting the isolation of a conscious principle from all material association.
- B. They are opposites in content: one names contentless isolation of consciousness, the other names omniscience, the fullest possible cognitive content.
- C. They are stages of a single path, the Sāṃkhya term naming the penultimate condition and the Jain term naming the final condition that follows it.
- D. They are the same doctrine under different school names, differing only in whether the liberated principle is described as one or as numerically many.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the shared syllable conceals opposite contents, and treating them as synonyms is the terminological trap the owner flags explicitly.
- **B:** Correct: Sāṃkhya aloneness is contentless while Jain *kevala* is omniscience, so the same syllable carries opposite doctrinal weight.
- **C:** Incorrect: they belong to different systems with incompatible metaphysics and are not stages of any single path.
- **D:** Incorrect: the difference is one of content rather than of number, and Sāṃkhya's plurality of consciousnesses is a separate doctrine.

Examiner trap 16: The shared syllable invites merger; an answer that separates omniscience from isolation in one sentence demonstrates control of the whole bench.

MCQ 17. Embodied liberation and the karma that remains

In Advaita, the continuing embodiment of one who has realised Brahman is explained by which doctrine, and with what consequence?

- A. By already-fructifying karma, which liberating knowledge does not cancel, so the body continues on residual momentum until it falls at *videhamukti*.
- B. By stored karma, which liberating knowledge preserves intact, so the liberated knower must exhaust the whole accumulated store before release occurs.
- C. By future karma, which the liberated knower continues to accumulate, so embodiment persists as long as further action generates further binding results.
- D. By divine decree, which sustains the liberated body for the benefit of others, so embodiment is a commission rather than a residue of prior action.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: knowledge destroys the stored and future portions while the fructifying portion runs its course, which the potter's-wheel image illustrates.
- **B:** Incorrect: the stored portion is precisely what knowledge destroys, and retaining it would make liberation while living impossible.
- **C:** Incorrect: the liberated knower accumulates no binding future karma, since the agency-sense that binds has been dismantled.
- **D:** Incorrect: Advaita explains the residual body by karmic momentum rather than by a commission, and no such decree is part of the doctrine.

Examiner trap 17: Saying knowledge destroys *prārabdha* makes embodied liberation self-contradictory and forfeits the central distinction of the 2025 stem.

MCQ 18. Liberation without a real agent

Consider the following statements about the Advaita and Viśiṣṭādvaita answers to whether liberation can be conceived without a real agent.

1. Advaita locates agency in the empirical individual and treats bondage and release as stated from the standpoint of ignorance.
2. Viśiṣṭādvaita holds that an unreal agent could not undertake real striving, real devotion or receive a real reward.
3. Advaita must explain how a superimposed individual undertakes a genuine discipline.
4. Viśiṣṭādvaita avoids all difficulty, since a really distinct soul raises no further question about its dependence on God.

Which of the statements are correct?

- A. Statements 1 and 4 only, since Advaita's level-distinction and the untroubled realism of Viśiṣṭādvaita exhaust the philosophical situation.
- B. Statements 2 and 4 only, since the objection to Advaita is decisive and the theistic school pays no corresponding price for its realism.
- C. Statements 1, 2 and 3 only, since each school states its position clearly and Advaita's cost is the intelligibility of discipline for a superimposed self.
- D. Statements 1, 3 and 4 only, since Viśiṣṭādvaita's objection is not to the reality of the agent but only to the possibility of embodied liberation.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: statement 4 is false, because Viśiṣṭādvaita must still explain how a really distinct soul is nonetheless wholly dependent on God.
- **B:** Incorrect: statement 2 is correct but statement 4 is not, and the owner is explicit that each position pays a price.
- **C:** Correct: the first three statements are the owner's, and the honest verdict is that both schools carry a cost rather than one being unscathed.
- **D:** Incorrect: statement 4 remains false, and the Viśiṣṭādvaita objection concerns the reality of the agent rather than embodied liberation.

Examiner trap 18: Answering this stem by praising one school and dismissing the other loses the evaluative marks, which are reserved for pricing both positions.

MCQ 19. The Jain ladder from bondage to release

Which sequence states the Jain analysis of bondage and its reversal in the correct order?

- A. Passions produce inflow, inflow produces bondage, restraint produces stoppage, austerity produces shedding, and the soul's own infinitudes then manifest.
- B. Bondage produces passions, passions produce austerity, austerity produces inflow, stoppage produces omniscience, and the soul acquires its infinitudes.
- C. Inflow produces passions, passions produce stoppage, stoppage produces bondage, shedding produces embodiment, and the soul is absorbed into the whole.
- D. Austerity produces inflow, inflow produces stoppage, stoppage produces passions, bondage produces omniscience, and the soul is created anew at release.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: this is the owner's ladder from *āsrava* through *bandha* to *saṃvara* and *nirjarā*, ending in manifested rather than acquired perfection.
- **B:** Incorrect: the order is scrambled, and it makes bondage prior to the passions that in fact cause the soul to become adhesive.
- **C:** Incorrect: stoppage cannot produce bondage, and the Jain liberated soul is never absorbed into any larger whole.
- **D:** Incorrect: austerity sheds rather than attracts karmic matter, and the soul is eternal rather than created at any point.

Examiner trap 19: A stem asking for "soul **and** bondage" carries two obligations, and delivering the metaphysics without the four-stage mechanism answers only half of it.

MCQ 20. What Sāṃkhya says about who is bound

Sāṃkhya-kārikā 62-63 makes which claim, and why does it matter for this clause?

- A. That *puruṣa* alone is bound and released, which matters because it makes Sāṃkhya the clearest Indian statement of a substantial transmigrating soul.
- B. That *prakṛti* alone is conscious, which matters because it removes the need for a second principle and reduces the system to a single-substance view.
- C. That strictly no *puruṣa* is bound, released or transmigrating, since it is *prakṛti* who binds, transmigrates and releases herself; liberation corrects a misattribution.
- D. That liberation is impossible before death, which matters because it distinguishes Sāṃkhya from Advaita's doctrine of liberation while the body persists.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the *kārikās* assert precisely the opposite, and this reading is the error the owner marks as the module's most costly.
- **B:** Incorrect: *prakṛti* is unconscious by definition, and the distinctness of consciousness from it is the argument for *puruṣa*.
- **C:** Correct: liberation is an epistemic correction rather than an ontological change, which is the highest-value item in the Sāṃkhya module.
- **D:** Incorrect: *kārikās* 67-68 grant embodied aloneness on the potter's-wheel model, with disembodied aloneness at the fall of the body.

Examiner trap 20: Writing that *puruṣa* is bound and then released contradicts the school's own text and undoes the distinction between correction and change.

MCQ 21. The Nyāya route to release

Which reconstruction of the Nyāya path from suffering to release is correct?

- A. Suffering arises from divine decree; petition removes the decree; petition ends activity; and release is the reward of a life of properly directed worship.
- B. Suffering arises from matter; austerity destroys matter; destruction of matter ends birth; and release is the manifestation of the soul's infinite knowledge.
- C. Suffering arises from craving; the eightfold path ends craving; ending craving ends formations; and release is the extinguishing of the conditioned stream.
- D. Suffering arises through birth, activity, defect and false knowledge; true knowledge removes false knowledge; and the chain unwinds to absolute cessation of pain.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Nyāya's God ratifies karmic desert rather than decreeing suffering, and release comes through knowledge rather than petition.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is the Jain account, in which karma is quasi-material and austerity performs the shedding.
- **C:** Incorrect: this is the Buddhist account, and its terminus is the extinguishing of craving rather than the cessation of pain in a self-substance.
- **D:** Correct: cutting the chain at false knowledge unwinds everything downstream, which is exactly why *apavarga* is stated negatively.

Examiner trap 21: Blending the Nyāya chain with the Buddhist one produces a hybrid that belongs to neither school and is penalised as school-confusion.

MCQ 22. Devotion, grace and effort

The cat and monkey illustrations (*mānjāra*- and *markaṭa-nyāya*) are used in the Śrīvaiṣṇava tradition to state which problem?

- A. The problem of whether devotion is superior to knowledge, the cat standing for effortless insight and the monkey for the laborious study of scripture.
- B. The problem of how grace and effort combine, the cat carrying the kitten standing for grace alone and the clinging young monkey for grace with effort.
- C. The problem of whether devotion may be directed to a formless ultimate, the cat standing for image-worship and the monkey for interior contemplation.
- D. The problem of whether liberation preserves individuality, the cat standing for absorption into God and the monkey for eternal service in communion.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the illustrations concern the grace-effort relation and not the relative rank of devotion and knowledge.
- **B:** Correct: the Teṅkalai and Vaḍakalai positions are stated by these two images, which is the most efficient way to display the problem.
- **C:** Incorrect: the with-form and formless distinction is a separate typological matter and is not what these images encode.
- **D:** Incorrect: the persistence of individuality is settled by Viśiṣṭādvaita's metaphysics rather than by either illustration.

Examiner trap 22: Treating devotion as mere emotion loses the structural point that its contribution is the shift from achievement to reception through grace.

MCQ 23. The three-means dispute, correctly located

Which statement best captures how this owner wants the knowledge-action-devotion question answered?

- A. All three are equally direct means, so the correct answer harmonises the schools and treats the apparent disagreement as verbal rather than substantive.
- B. Only action is a means, since the Vedic corpus is essentially injunctive and knowledge-passages exist to supply the results that ritual action secures.
- C. Only devotion is a means, since the beginninglessly bound soul cannot lift itself and every school ultimately concedes that grace alone can liberate.
- D. All three are means of different kinds - action qualifies, devotion receives, knowledge removes - and which is direct follows from whether release is produced or uncovered.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: harmonising is exactly what the owner forbids, since the schools disagree substantively about which means is direct.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is the Mīmāṃsā position, which the owner presents as one party to the dispute rather than as its resolution.
- **C:** Incorrect: Advaita denies that devotion is directly liberating, so the claim that every school concedes this is false.
- **D:** Correct: naming the disagreement and grounding it in the production-versus-removal fork is the owner's stated verdict formula.

Examiner trap 23: "All three are equal" is the single most common closing sentence on this stem, and it forfeits every mark reserved for naming the disagreement.

MCQ 24. Resurrection and rebirth compared

Which row of the resurrection-rebirth comparison is stated correctly?

- A. Number of lives: resurrection posits a beginningless series, while rebirth concentrates all moral settlement into one earthly life and a final judgement.
- B. Telos: resurrection aims at restored embodied life in communion with God, while rebirth aims at exit from the series into release or extinguishing.
- C. Judge: resurrection leaves desert to an impersonal law, while rebirth requires a personal God to allocate each fruit to its appropriate recipient.
- D. Body: resurrection discards the body as a worn-out garment, while rebirth treats the raised body as essential to the identity of the person restored.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the two columns are reversed, since resurrection posits one life and rebirth a beginningless series.
- **B:** Correct: restored embodiment before God against exit from the series is the clearest structural contrast on the owner's grid.
- **C:** Incorrect: this also reverses the columns, since it is rebirth that operates by self-regulating law and resurrection that involves a judge.
- **D:** Incorrect: the body is discarded in rebirth and essential in resurrection, so the attributions are again the wrong way round.

Examiner trap 24: Presenting resurrection as rebirth in heaven merges two structurally opposed doctrines and destroys the comparison the 2019 stem requires.

Remedial drills - the eight errors that cost marks on this clause

MCQ 25. Remedial: is resurrection a variety of rebirth?

A candidate writes that resurrection is simply rebirth into a heavenly world. Which correction is accurate?

- A. The correction is unnecessary, since both doctrines describe a post-mortem continuation and the difference between them is one of religious idiom only.
- B. Resurrection is indeed rebirth in heaven, but the term should be avoided because Christian writers prefer to speak of the raising of the whole person.
- C. Resurrection is one life, a divine re-constitution of an embodied person and a final judgement, whereas rebirth is renewed embodiment within a series.
- D. Resurrection differs only in lacking karma, so once a divine judge replaces the impersonal law the two doctrines become structurally indistinguishable.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the doctrines differ in number of lives, mechanism, judge, telos, identity-bearer, treatment of the body and direction of time.
- **B:** Incorrect: this concedes the substantive error while objecting only to vocabulary, which leaves the misunderstanding in place.
- **C:** Correct: this is the owner's contrast, and Cullmann's title makes the opposition of the two frameworks explicit.
- **D:** Incorrect: replacing the law with a judge leaves untouched the difference between one life and a beginningless series.

Examiner trap 25: Because both doctrines are "life after death", candidates assimilate them; the examiner is testing whether the two structures are kept apart.

MCQ 26. Remedial: what *nāstika* means

A candidate glosses *nāstika* as "atheist" and concludes that Jainism must deny the soul. Which correction is accurate?

- A. The gloss is acceptable, since rejecting Vedic authority and rejecting a creator amount in practice to the same philosophical commitment.
- B. *Nāstika* marks rejection of Vedic authority rather than atheism, and Jainism denies a creator while affirming an eternal individual soul.
- C. *Nāstika* marks rejection of the soul rather than of the Veda, so the conclusion about Jainism follows correctly from the classification.
- D. *Nāstika* marks rejection of rebirth, so both Buddhism and Jainism are misclassified by the term and should be described as orthodox systems.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the two rejections are logically independent, and Mīmāṃsā accepts the Veda while assigning no role to a creator.
- **B:** Correct: the label concerns scriptural authority, and Jainism's eternal soul coexists with its denial of a creator God.
- **C:** Incorrect: the term has never meant denial of the soul, and Jainism's soul-realism refutes the inference drawn from it.
- **D:** Incorrect: both traditions affirm rebirth, so the proposed gloss fails on its own terms as well as historically.

Examiner trap 26: The mistranslation of *nāstika* generates a chain of errors, most damagingly the claim that Jainism must deny the soul it in fact makes eternal.

MCQ 27. Remedial: how far the anti-theistic case goes

A candidate concludes that Buddhism and Jainism refute theism because they explain karma and liberation without a God. Which correction is accurate?

- A. The conclusion holds, since an explanation that dispenses with a God shows that the God-hypothesis is false rather than merely unnecessary.
- B. The conclusion holds for Jainism only, since its eternal souls exclude a creator, while Buddhism leaves the question of a creator entirely open.
- C. The conclusion fails because both traditions in fact presuppose a divine ordering principle under a different name, so no genuine detachment occurs.
- D. The conclusion overreaches: what is shown is detachability - that karma needs no judge, rebirth no soul and liberation no grace - not that no God exists.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: dispensability is not falsity, and the owner's discipline restricts the claim to what the structure does not require.
- **B:** Incorrect: Buddhism's denial of a creator is explicit, so the restriction to Jainism misreports both traditions.
- **C:** Incorrect: no such ordering principle is smuggled in; the moral law is treated as a basic feature of how things work.
- **D:** Correct: the three detachments are the significance-claim, and stating them as such is what the 2018 stem rewards.

Examiner trap 27: Reading "philosophically significant" as "successful refutation" turns a structural observation into a polemic the sources do not support.

MCQ 28. Remedial: two-obligation stems

A stem reads: "Elucidate the concept of liberation according to Advaita Vedānta. Explain the role of knowledge in the attainment of liberation." What does the directive require?

- A. A single continuous account of Advaita metaphysics, since the second sentence merely restates the first in the vocabulary of epistemology.
- B. Two equally weighted parts - the concept of release, then the specific role of knowledge as the sole operative cause on the removal model.
- C. A comparison with Viśiṣṭādvaita, since the role of knowledge can only be exhibited against a school that assigns knowledge a different function.
- D. An account of the fourfold qualification alone, since the disciplines that precede knowledge are what the phrase "role of knowledge" refers to.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the two sentences impose distinct obligations, and collapsing them leaves half the demand unaddressed.
- **B:** Correct: the directive decoder treats "elucidate... and explain the role of..." as two obligations that must both be delivered.
- **C:** Incorrect: comparison may enrich the answer but is not what the stem demands, and it cannot substitute for the second obligation.
- **D:** Incorrect: the fourfold qualification is preparatory, whereas the role of knowledge concerns its function as the cause that removes ignorance.

Examiner trap 28: Two-verb stems are the commonest silent mark-loss in this clause, because a strong answer to half the question still scores as half an answer.

MCQ 29. Remedial: does no-self mean no continuity?

A candidate writes that Buddhism, by denying the self, thereby denies personal continuity and moral responsibility. Which correction is accurate?

- A. Buddhism denies a permanent, independent substance-self while retaining the conventional person, causal continuity, rebirth and moral consequence.
- B. Buddhism denies continuity as well as the self, and accepts the consequence that moral responsibility is a useful fiction with no ultimate standing.
- C. Buddhism denies the self only in meditation contexts, and restores a substantial self whenever questions of rebirth or responsibility arise.
- D. Buddhism denies the body rather than the self, so continuity is preserved by a mental substance that passes intact from one embodiment to the next.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the position is a middle course between an eternal self and annihilation, and it retains everything the objection assumes it discards.
- **B:** Incorrect: responsibility is grounded in causal descent rather than abandoned, and the tradition argues the point explicitly.
- **C:** Incorrect: no such contextual restoration occurs; the denial is systematic and is precisely what the rebirth account is built to accommodate.
- **D:** Incorrect: this substitutes a mental substance for the self, which is the very transmigrating entity the doctrine denies.

Examiner trap 29: "No self, therefore no continuity" is the error that makes Buddhism look self-refuting; the counter-example only works once the distinction is stated.

MCQ 30. Remedial: is apavarga a state of bliss?

A candidate describes Nyāya release as eternal bliss enjoyed by the liberated self. Which correction is accurate?

- A. The description is correct, since every Indian school characterises its terminus as blissful and Nyāya is no exception to this general pattern.
- B. The description is correct for Vaiśeṣika but not for Nyāya, since the two systems diverge on whether release retains any experiential content.
- C. The description should be softened to "peace", since Nyāya allows a residual positive feeling once all painful qualities have finally ceased.
- D. The description is wrong: consciousness is adventitious to the Nyāya self, so release ends pain together with the qualities that sustain any experience.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Sāṃkhya likewise refuses to call its terminus blissful, so the supposed general pattern does not hold.
- **B:** Incorrect: the allied systems agree on this point, and no such divergence is recorded in the owner.
- **C:** Incorrect: no residual positive feeling is admitted, since the conditions for any experience whatsoever have ended.
- **D:** Correct: the negative characterisation follows directly from treating consciousness as a quality arising only on conjunction with body and mind.

Examiner trap 30: Adding bliss to *apavarga* makes the Nyāya answer internally inconsistent and simultaneously erases the contrast with Advaitic release.

MCQ 31. Remedial: what liberating knowledge destroys

A candidate writes that liberating knowledge in Advaita destroys all karma, including the portion already fructifying. Which correction is accurate?

- A. The claim is correct, and the continuing body of the liberated knower is therefore explained by the compassionate will of God rather than by karma.
- B. The claim is wrong: knowledge destroys stored and future karma, while already-fructifying karma runs its course, which is why embodied liberation is possible.
- C. The claim is wrong: knowledge destroys only future karma, so the liberated knower must still exhaust the entire accumulated store before release.
- D. The claim is correct for Sāṃkhya but not for Advaita, since only the former allows aloneness to be reached while the body continues to function.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Advaita explains the residual body by karmic momentum, and no divine sustaining will is invoked at this point.
- **B:** Correct: the distinction between the destroyed portions and the fructifying remainder is what makes liberation while living intelligible.
- **C:** Incorrect: the stored portion is destroyed by knowledge, and requiring its exhaustion would make embodied liberation impossible.
- **D:** Incorrect: both traditions allow embodied liberation, and both use the potter's-wheel image for the residual momentum.

Examiner trap 31: Erasing the fructifying remainder removes the only mechanism the school has for explaining why a liberated knower still has a body.

MCQ 32. Remedial: the kevala trap and who transmigrates

A candidate writes that Sāṃkhya's *kaivalya* is the omniscience of a liberated *puruṣa* that has transmigrated through many bodies. How many distinct errors does this contain, and what are they?

- A. One error only: *kaivalya* should be described as bliss rather than omniscience, while the account of transmigration is accurate as it stands.
- B. One error only: *puruṣa* does not transmigrate, while omniscience is an accurate description of the content of Sāṃkhya's liberated state.
- C. Two errors: *kaivalya* is contentless isolation rather than omniscience, and it is *prakṛti* rather than *puruṣa* that binds and transmigrates.
- D. Three errors: *kaivalya* is annihilation, *puruṣa* is one rather than many, and transmigration belongs to the Vedāntic rather than the Sāṃkhya system.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Sāṃkhya explicitly denies that aloneness is bliss, and the transmigration claim is the module's flagged error.
- **B:** Incorrect: the transmigration point is right but omniscience is wrong, since *kevala-jñāna* belongs to Jainism rather than to Sāṃkhya.
- **C:** Correct: kārikās 62-63 assign binding and transmigration to *prakṛti*, and aloneness is contentless rather than omniscient.
- **D:** Incorrect: aloneness is not annihilation, *puruṣa* is plural in Sāṃkhya, and transmigration is affirmed within the system.

Examiner trap 32: Two flagged traps combine in one sentence here, which is why examiners treat this formulation as diagnostic of an unread Sāṃkhya module.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved previous-year questions - all 17 verified owner parts, 2018-2025

Ledger discipline. Exact wording, year and marks are reproduced from the audited local Philosophy of Religion Paper II bank for 2018-2025. This clause owns exactly **17** primary parts out of 112 - 2018:2, 2019:1, 2020:2, 2021:3, 2022:3, 2023:2, 2024:2, 2025:2. Paper I questions that merely mention release or the soul are **not** counted here. UPSC publishes no descriptive model answer for Philosophy Paper II; every model below is independent learner practice.

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): How far is it plausible to argue that the anti-theistic religions' stand on the concept of rebirth is philosophically significant?

Demand decoding. "How far is it plausible" asks for a **graded verdict**, not a description. "Anti-theistic religions" means the Veda-rejecting traditions, principally Buddhism and Jainism. "Philosophically significant" must be read structurally - what their position shows about what rebirth *requires* - and not as praise.

Model answer (≈150 words). The anti-theistic traditions are philosophically significant because they demonstrate three detachments. **First, karma without a judge:** in Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā the moral law is self-regulating, so desert is discharged without a divine allocator, answering the distribution question by structure rather than by theodicy. **Second, rebirth without a soul:** Buddhism affirms re-becoming (*punarbhava*) while denying a permanent self (*anātman*), so continuity, not substance, is what rebirth requires. **Third, liberation without grace:** extinguishing (*nirvāṇa*) and Jain perfected omniscience need neither deity nor divine favour. Jainism removes the God while keeping the soul; Buddhism removes the soul while keeping rebirth - together they show the whole structure separable from both. **Verdict:** the significance is high but strictly structural. It establishes detachability and shifts the burden onto those who claim a judge or a substance adds explanatory work; it does not amount to a refutation of theism.

Marks rationale. The examiner is buying (i) the reading of "significant" as a modal claim, (ii) three named detachments rather than a survey, (iii) the Jain/Buddhist asymmetry, and (iv) an explicit limit on the conclusion.

Timing skeleton (10 minutes). 1 min plan · 1 min thesis · 5 min three detachments with named schools · 2 min asymmetry · 1 min bounded verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Glossing *nāstika* as "atheist"; merging the Buddhist and Jain positions; converting detachability into a disproof of theism.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 Q7(c), 15 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Evaluate the concept of Bhakti (Devotion) as a pathway to attain liberation.

Demand decoding. "Evaluate... as a pathway" demands assessment of **efficacy**, which requires a stated criterion. Description of devotional practice earns almost nothing; the marks are in accessibility, sufficiency and terminus.

Model answer (≈250 words). Criterion first. A pathway must be judged on accessibility, sufficiency and terminus.

Textual base. *Bhagavad Gītā* 18.66 makes surrender the text's final instruction; 9.22 and 9.32 state the Lord's securing and the path's openness. *Bhāgavata Purāṇa* 7.5.23 lists the nine limbs (*navadhā bhakti*): hearing, praising, remembering, service at the feet, worship, salutation, servitude, friendship and self-offering. The *Nārada* and *Śaṇḍilya Bhakti Sūtras* define devotion as supreme love or attachment to the Lord.

Typology. Higher and preliminary (*parā/aparā*); rule-governed and spontaneous (*vaidhī/rāgānugā*); with-form (Tulsīdās, Sūrdās, Mīrābāī) and formless (Kabīr, Nānak, Dādū) - the last showing devotion requires a *personal focus*, not an iconic form.

Systematic positions. Rāmānuja treats devotion as steady loving recollection (*dhruvānusmṛti*), with self-surrender (*prapatti*) as the universally accessible alternative and grace as decisive; the cat and monkey illustrations (*mānjāra/markaṭa-nyāya*) state the grace-effort problem exactly. Madhva requires knowledge-preceded affection; Vallabha teaches nourishing grace; Caitanya makes love a fifth human end. Advaita makes devotion preparatory - purification of mind (*citta-suddhi*) - not directly liberating.

Assessment. Accessibility is its greatest strength, dispensing with Sanskrit learning and ritual entitlement, which explains the vernacular Bhakti movement. Its strongest philosophical claim is the incapacity argument: a beginninglessly bound soul cannot lift itself, and devotion is the posture in which grace is received. Against it: love presupposes duality, so it cannot deliver Advaitic identity; emotionalism is a real risk; and it presupposes a personal focus unavailable to strictly non-theistic systems.

Verdict. Devotion is a complete path in the theistic Vedāntas and a preparatory discipline in Advaita. Its significance is not emotional but structural: it relocates liberation from achievement to reception.

Marks rationale. Criterion-first evaluation, precise verse citation in order, the grace-effort dispute named, the achievement-to-reception thesis stated explicitly, and the school-relative sufficiency verdict.

Timing skeleton (15 minutes). 2 min plan · 1 min criterion · 4 min textual base and typology · 4 min systematic positions · 3 min assessment · 1 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Describing devotional practice instead of evaluating it; saying "Advaita rejects bhakti"; attributing the *Vivekacūḍāmaṇi* definition to Śaṅkara personally.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 Q8(a), 20 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): State and explain the doctrines of Karma, Rebirth and Reincarnation in Hinduism.

Demand decoding. "State and explain" imposes two obligations; "A, B and C" requires all three defined **separately** and then related. The examiner's hidden test is whether rebirth and reincarnation are distinguished.

Model answer (≈300 words). Thesis. Karma, rebirth and reincarnation are linked but non-identical: karma supplies the mechanism, rebirth the field, and "reincarnation" a school-specific substantialist reading of that field.

Karma. Act together with its unseen potency (*adṛṣṭa*; in Mīmāṃsā *apūrva*), which persists until it matures. It is classified as stored (*sañcita*), already-fructifying (*prārabdha*) and future (*āgāmi*). It is moral causation, not fatalism: human effort (*puruṣakāra*) operates within inherited destiny (*daiva*), acting on future karma and, through liberating knowledge, on the stored portion. Administration divides - self-regulating in the anti-theistic schools, superintended by God (*karmādhyaṣa*) in Nyāya and the theistic Vedāntas, where God ratifies desert rather than authoring it.

Rebirth. Re-embodiment (*punarjanma*) within a beginningless wandering-on (*saṃsāra*). The subtle body (*sūkṣma-śarīra*) carries latent dispositions (*saṃskāra/vāsanā*). *Gītā* 2.22 gives the image of worn-out garments; 9.21 shows that even heaven is a within-*saṃsāra* stage, since the meritorious return when merit is exhausted. Its function is to widen the temporal field in which karmic consequence can mature, so that an exceptionless moral law is not falsified by a single life.

Reincarnation. In careful usage, *re-enfleshing* presupposes a **substantial soul** re-entering a body - apt for Vedānta, Nyāya and Jainism. Rebirth is the wider, neutral term and the only correct one for Buddhism's re-becoming (*punarbhava*) without a transmigrating substance. Sanskrit registers the range: *punarjanma*, *punarāvṛtti*, *saṃsāra*.

Contrast and criticism. Resurrection is the structural opposite - one life, divine re-constitution, final judgement; Cullmann (1955) argues Greek immortality and Hebrew resurrection are opposed rather than complementary. Against rebirth: the memory objection, unverifiability, and the risk of victim-blaming. Replies: memory is not continuity; unverifiability is shared with eschatology; explanation licenses no social judgement.

Conclusion. Karma is the mechanism, rebirth the field, and reincarnation a substantialist reading of that field which Buddhism refuses.

Marks rationale. Three separate definitions, then their interlocking; the reincarnation/rebirth distinction the stem is built to test; a named Western comparator; and criticisms with replies.

Timing skeleton (20 minutes). 3 min plan · 2 min thesis · 5 min karma · 4 min rebirth · 3 min reincarnation distinction · 2 min contrast and criticism · 1 min conclusion.

Penalties to avoid. Defining only two of the three; using "reincarnation" for Buddhism; omitting the threefold karma classification.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2020 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): The concept of 'Immortality' is a basic presupposition of religion. Elaborate your answer.

Demand decoding. A quoted thesis with "elaborate your answer" - the candidate must take a position and defend it. The strongest answer accepts the thesis in a qualified form and states the counter-cases.

Model answer (≈150 words). Immortality functions as a **presupposition** in several religious frameworks, but not as a universal one. It is presupposed wherever (i) moral desert must be completed beyond the visible life, (ii) worship is directed to a relation that death cannot terminate, and (iii) liberation or salvation is offered as an ultimate good. Kant's practical postulate is the sharpest philosophical statement of (i): the moral law demands a completion no single life supplies, so immortality is postulated rather than proved. In the Indian frameworks, the deathlessness of the self is presupposed by rebirth and by release alike. **But the thesis is not universal.** Early Hebrew religion is largely this-worldly, and Buddhism reaches liberation with no deathless soul at all, affirming re-becoming through causal continuity. **Verdict:** immortality is a widespread and often load-bearing presupposition, but the correct claim is that religions presuppose a *continuity-bearer* adequate to their soteriology - not always an immortal soul.

Marks rationale. A qualified acceptance, the presupposition analysed into three functions, Kant named, and two decisive counter-cases that convert a slogan into a thesis.

Timing skeleton (10 minutes). 1 min plan · 2 min three functions · 3 min Kant and the Indian case · 3 min counter-cases · 1 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Agreeing without qualification; omitting the Buddhist counter-case; treating immortality as identical with resurrection.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2020 Q8(c), 15 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Do you accept that Knowledge, Action and Devotion are the means to attain liberation in Indian tradition? Discuss.

Demand decoding. "Do you accept...? Discuss" requires an explicit position first, then reasons, then the strongest contrary case. The examiner's test is whether the candidate **names the disagreement** rather than harmonising.

Model answer (≈250 words). Position. I accept that all three are means, but deny that they are means of the same kind - and the real question is which is *direct*.

Apparatus. Three distinctions decide everything: direct means (*sākṣāt-sādhana*) versus auxiliary aid (*ārād-upakāra*); means versus qualification (*adhikāra*); and the **production** versus **removal** model of liberation. If release is a result to be produced, action can produce it; if it is the removal of an error, only knowledge removes it.

The positions. Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā: action alone, since the Veda is essentially injunctive. Śaṅkara: knowledge alone liberates, because release is not a producible effect (*sādhya*) but the eternally accomplished nature of the self (*siddha*) obscured by ignorance; he therefore rejects the knowledge-and-action combination (*jñāna-karma-samuccaya-vāda*), while retaining action and worship as preparation producing purity of mind and the fourfold qualification, matured through hearing, reflecting and meditating. Rāmānuja: sequential culmination - action purifies, knowledge discloses the self as a mode of God, both flow into devotion as the direct means, with self-surrender as the accessible alternative. Madhva: knowledge-grounded devotion, with grace decisive.

The text's own signal. *Gītā* 5.4-5 says only the immature (*bālāḥ*) declare knowledge and action different - which is why Śaṅkara, Rāmānuja and Tilak could each claim the text. Vivekananda's four yogas are temperament-matched, a psychological rather than metaphysical pluralism.

Objection and reply. Objection: convergence is diplomatic mush, since knowledge dissolving individuality and devotion preserving it cannot terminate in one state. Reply: they converge in *function* - dismantling egoic appropriation - and diverge in *terminus*.

Conclusion. Action qualifies, devotion receives, knowledge removes. Which is direct follows from a prior question: is liberation produced or uncovered?

Marks rationale. Position stated first; the three-distinction apparatus deployed early; four schools named with their exact claims; the *Gītā* signal; and a verdict that names the disagreement instead of dissolving it.

Timing skeleton (15 minutes). 2 min plan · 1 min position · 3 min apparatus · 5 min four positions · 2 min *Gītā* and objection · 2 min conclusion.

Penalties to avoid. Concluding "all three are equal"; omitting *Mīmāṃsā*, which is why the dispute exists; describing devotion without its direct-means claim.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2021 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Discuss the concept of immortality of soul with special reference to Hindu tradition.

Demand decoding. "With special reference to" fixes the evidence base; "Hindu tradition" is not one position, so the answer must be **school-differentiated**. A generic account of an eternal soul will score in the average band.

Model answer (≈300 words). Thesis. In the Hindu traditions immortality is not a reward that follows death but the standing nature of the self; the schools then differ sharply on what that deathless thing is.

The shared frame. The self (*ātman*) is beginningless and indestructible. *Gītā* 2.23 states that weapons, fire, water and wind cannot destroy it; 2.22 gives re-embodiment as the changing of worn-out garments; 9.21 shows that heaven is a stage inside the wandering-on, since the meritorious return when merit is exhausted. The subtle body (*sūkṣma-śarīra*), carrying latent dispositions, is the **vehicle** of continuity and must not be mistaken for the continuant.

The supports offered. (i) Continuity of the knower: waking, dream and deep sleep vary and are known as varying, so the witness of their variation is not one of them. (ii) Moral bookkeeping: act and fruit are separated by more time than a life provides. (iii) Scriptural testimony (*śabda*) as a valid means in supersensible matters - a presupposition to be named, not smuggled. (iv) Beginninglessness (*anādi*), which blocks the question when the soul first fell.

The schools. Advaita: the self is non-dual awareness identical with Brahman; bondage is ignorance, and individuality is sublated at release. Viśiṣṭādvaita: the soul is an eternal individual, a mode (*prakāra*) of God, which reaches God without becoming God. Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika: an eternal self-substance to which consciousness is *adventitious*, so release (*apavarga*) is existence without consciousness or bliss. Sāṃkhya-Yoga: *puruṣa* is plural contentless consciousness, and strictly it neither transmigrates nor is bound (*Sāṃkhya-kārikā* 62-63).

Objection and reply. The memory objection asks why nothing of earlier lives is recalled; the reply distinguishes episodic memory from dispositional continuity, though empirical warrant remains contested.

Conclusion. "Hindu immortality" names a shared conviction of the self's deathlessness housing at least four incompatible accounts of what is deathless - and the marks lie in the differentiation.

Marks rationale. Verse fidelity, the vehicle/continuant distinction, four named schools with their exact commitments, an objection with a qualified reply, and a differentiating conclusion.

Timing skeleton (20 minutes). 3 min plan · 2 min thesis · 4 min shared frame with verses · 4 min supports · 5 min four schools · 2 min objection and conclusion.

Penalties to avoid. Writing "Hinduism believes"; confusing the subtle body with the self; making Nyāya release blissful.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2021 Q6(b), 15 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Elucidate the concept of liberation according to Advaita Vedānta. Explain the role of knowledge in the attainment of liberation.

Demand decoding. Two obligations, equally weighted. Half the answer elucidates release; half explains the role of knowledge. Delivering only the first is the standard silent mark-loss.

Model answer (≈250 words). Part 1 - the concept. In Advaita, bondage is not a real chain but a **cognitive error**: the self, non-different from Brahman, is taken to be a limited individual. Release (*mokṣa*) is therefore not produced. What is produced can be destroyed, whereas the self's freedom is eternally accomplished (*siddha*) and merely obscured by ignorance (*avidyā*). Release is available **while living** (*jīvanmukti*): the knower of Brahman is free now, the body continuing on already-fructifying karma (*prārabdha*) - the potter's wheel still turning after the hand is withdrawn - until *videhamukti* at its fall. Individuality is not annihilated but **sublated**: shown to have been superimposed.

Part 2 - the role of knowledge. On the removal model, knowledge is not one contributory cause among several but the **sole operative cause**, because the obstacle is cognitive: ignorance is destroyed by knowledge as darkness by light. Ritual action and worship (*upāsana*) are indispensable but only as **qualification and purification** - they generate purity of mind (*citta-śuddhi*) and the fourfold qualification (*sādhana-catuṣṭaya*: discrimination, dispassion, the six accomplishments, the desire for release). Knowledge then matures through **hearing, reflecting and meditating** (*śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana*). Śaṅkara accordingly rejects the knowledge-and-action combination (*jñāna-karma-samuccaya-vāda*).

Objection and reply. If ignorance is destroyed, why does embodied life continue? Advaita distinguishes the destruction of stored and future karma from the momentum of an embodiment already under way; critics reply that a residue seems reintroduced, and the school locates it in the body-mind complex rather than in the knower.

Conclusion. Release is the removal of an error, and knowledge is its only remover; everything else qualifies the candidate rather than producing the result.

Marks rationale. Both obligations delivered in balance, the removal model named as the reason for knowledge's monopoly, the embodied-liberation mechanism stated exactly, and the combination doctrine explicitly rejected.

Timing skeleton (15 minutes). 2 min plan · 5 min concept · 5 min role of knowledge · 2 min objection · 1 min conclusion.

Penalties to avoid. Answering only the concept; saying knowledge destroys fructifying karma; describing sublation as annihilation.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2021 Q8(b), 15 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Discuss and evaluate the doctrine of Karma as an essential postulate of Hinduism.

Demand decoding. "Discuss and evaluate" plus "essential postulate" - the candidate must show what would break if karma were removed, and then price the doctrine's costs.

Model answer (≈250 words). Statement. Karma is act together with its unseen potency (*adr̥ṣṭa/apūrvā*), classified as stored, already-fructifying and future, operating within a beginningless series.

Why it is essential, not merely held. Remove karma and four commitments fail. (i) The **distribution** of fortune becomes arbitrary, and the tradition loses its answer to unequal suffering. (ii) **Rebirth loses its rationale**, since nothing would require a further life. (iii) **Liberation loses its content**, since there would be no bondage to be freed from. (iv) In Mīmāṃsā, **ritual injunction loses its efficacy**, since *apūrvā* is what links sacrifice to distant result. That is the test of a postulate: not that it is believed, but that its removal disables the rest of the system.

It is not fatalism. The threefold classification exists precisely to locate freedom: effort (*puruṣakāra*) generates future karma and, through liberating knowledge, destroys the stored portion; only the fructifying portion runs its course. Desireless action (*niṣkāma-karma*) uses the law rather than escaping it.

Evaluation - the costs. (a) **Unverifiability:** the postulated links are not observable. (b) **Moral hazard:** present suffering may be read as evidence of past fault. (c) **The God-and-law problem:** either God is redundant, or subordinate to the law. **Replies:** unverifiability is shared with every eschatology; explanatory karma licenses no social judgement, and the duty of compassion is untouched; and the theistic schools answer (c) by making God the **superintendent** (*karmādhyaṣṭa*) who ratifies desert rather than authoring it.

Verdict. Karma is genuinely a postulate - system-enabling rather than merely traditional - but a postulate whose price is unverifiability and whose misuse is socially dangerous, and both must be stated.

Marks rationale. Postulate-status argued by removal test; fatalism refuted from the classification; three costs with replies; and a verdict that concedes the price.

Timing skeleton (15 minutes). 2 min plan · 2 min statement · 5 min removal test · 2 min anti-fatalism · 3 min costs and replies · 1 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Describing karma rather than arguing its postulate-status; omitting the victim-blaming control; making God the author of desert.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2022 Q5(c), 10 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): "Immortality of Soul is a necessary postulate for rebirth." Critically examine with reference to Buddhism.

Demand decoding. A quoted necessity claim, with the school of examination **named**. The answer must be modal and must run through the Buddhist account specifically.

Model answer (≈150 words). The claim. Substantialist systems - Vedānta, Nyāya, Jainism - do assert it: a persisting self (*ātman/jīva*) is what transmigrates, so on their metaphysics immortality is what makes rebirth possible.

The Buddhist counter-case. Buddhism affirms re-becoming (*punarbhava*) while denying a permanent self (*anātman*). Its argument runs: all conditioned factors are impermanent; no aggregate (*skandha*) is a self; craving and karmic formations condition future consciousness; therefore continuity occurs without an unchanging owner. The flame lit from a flame, and milk becoming curd, illustrate a stream that is **neither the same nor wholly other**.

Objection and reply. If nothing persists, who receives the fruit? Responsibility rests on **causal descent**, not substantial identity - though critics rightly press whether descent alone makes the fruit genuinely one's own.

Verdict. A deathless soul is **sufficient** for rebirth but not **necessary**. What rebirth requires is a continuity-bearer; the schools differ only on whether that bearer must be a substance.

Marks rationale. Substantialist case granted, the four-step Buddhist argument reconstructed, the ownership objection met, and the modal verdict stated in the stem's own vocabulary.

Timing skeleton (10 minutes). 1 min plan · 2 min substantialist case · 4 min Buddhist argument · 2 min objection · 1 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Saying Buddhism denies continuity; using the flame as proof; ending without the necessary/sufficient verdict.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2022 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Is it possible to have an idea of Liberation without the conception of a real agent? In this context, discuss the difference between Advaita and Viśiṣṭādvaita systems of thought.

Demand decoding. A conceptual question **plus** a named comparison. Both must be delivered, and the comparison must be organised by the question rather than appended to it.

Model answer (≈250 words). The question. Liberation appears to require someone who is bound, who strives and who is freed. The dispute is whether that "someone" must be *ultimately* real.

Advaita: yes, it is possible - and necessary. Agency belongs to the empirical individual, which is itself superimposed by ignorance (*avidyā*). At the ultimate level (*pāramārthika*) there is no agent, no bondage and therefore no one who is literally liberated; the tradition itself states that bondage and release are described from the standpoint of ignorance. Release is the removal of an error, and what is removed is precisely the mistaken individuality. Liberation while living (*jīvanmukti*) is intelligible on this model because nothing needs to be *acquired*.

Viśiṣṭādvaita: no, it is not possible. An unreal agent could not undertake real striving, real devotion, or receive a real reward. The soul (*jīva*) is an eternal individual, a mode (*prakāra*) of God - real, distinct and never absorbed. Bondage is beginningless karma and dependence; release is communion and service, reached through knowledge, devotion (*dhruvānusmṛti*) and self-surrender (*prapatti*), and given finally by grace. The soul reaches God; it never becomes God.

The honest evaluation. Each position pays a price. Advaita must explain how a superimposed individual undertakes a genuine discipline over a genuine period. Viśiṣṭādvaita must explain how a really distinct soul is nonetheless *wholly* dependent on God without collapsing into the very non-duality it rejects.

Verdict. The idea of liberation without a real agent is coherent, but only within a metaphysics that also makes bondage unreal. Whether that price is acceptable is exactly what divides the two Vedāntas.

Marks rationale. The conceptual question answered directly, the comparison organised by that answer, the level-distinction used precisely, and both costs priced.

Timing skeleton (15 minutes). 2 min plan · 2 min the question · 4 min Advaita · 4 min Viśiṣṭādvaita · 2 min costs · 1 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Appending a generic comparison; saying the soul is annihilated in Advaita or deified in Viśiṣṭādvaita; leaving one side unpriced.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2022 Q8(b), 15 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Discuss the nature of Soul and Bondage according to Jainism.

Demand decoding. Two nouns, both to be delivered: the soul's metaphysics *and* the bondage mechanism. The mechanism is the four-stage ladder, and omitting it halves the answer.

Model answer (≈250 words). The soul (jīva). Every living being is an eternal, conscious substance; consciousness is its defining and inseparable characteristic. It is uncreated and indestructible, and Jainism admits **no creator God**. Its intrinsic nature is the four infinitudes (*ananta-catuṣṭaya*): infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and energy. Distinctively, during bondage the soul is **co-extensive with the body it occupies**, expanding and contracting like light filling a room - a doctrine that follows from treating embodiment as a mode of the soul.

Bondage (bandha). Karma in Jainism is not merely an unseen potency but **fine matter** (*karma-pudgala*). The passions (*kaṣāya*) - anger, pride, deceit and greed - make the soul adhesive; karmic matter then flows in (*āsrava*) and binds, obscuring the four infinitudes. Bondage is analysed by **nature, duration, intensity and quantity** of the matter bound. The classical image is dust adhering to an **oily body**: the oil is passion, and without it the dust does not stick.

The reversal. Restraint, vows and carefulness stop the inflow (*saṃvara*); austerity (*tapas*) sheds accumulated karma (*nirjarā*); omniscience (*kevala-jñāna*) then manifests while the body still lives, and final disembodied perfection (*siddhahood*) follows.

Objection and reply. How can non-material consciousness interact with material karma? Jainism replies that extension and embodiment are **modes of the soul during bondage**, so the soul is not an unextended Cartesian thinker. The cost is that the soul becomes neither cleanly material nor cleanly spiritual.

Placement. Jain liberation therefore **perfects individuality** - neither Advaitic identity nor Buddhist cessation without a self - and its *kevala* means omniscience, not Sāṃkhya's contentless isolation.

Marks rationale. Both nouns delivered; the quasi-materiality of karma stated as doctrine rather than metaphor; the four-stage ladder complete; the interaction objection met; and the comparative placement.

Timing skeleton (15 minutes). 2 min plan · 4 min soul · 4 min bondage · 2 min reversal · 2 min objection · 1 min placement.

Penalties to avoid. Treating Jain karma as metaphor; omitting stoppage and shedding; confusing Jain *kevala* with Sāṃkhya *kaivalya*.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2023 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Critically examine Plato's apriori proofs for the immortality of the soul.

Demand decoding. "Critically examine... proofs" (plural) means **four separate assessments**, each with the objection that fits it - not one summary followed by one general complaint.

Model answer (≈300 words). Frame. In the *Phaedo* Plato argues from reason alone, and each argument must be asked what it separately establishes: pre-existence, indestructibility, or only likeness to the indestructible.

1. Opposites (cyclical). Opposites arise from opposites - larger from smaller, waking from sleeping - so the living arise from the dead and souls persist between deaths. *Assessment:* the pattern fits qualities admitting degree far better than existence and non-existence, and it yields a cosmic balance rather than the survival of *this* soul.

2. Recollection (anamnesis). We judge equal sticks *deficiently* equal, so we possess a standard sense-experience cannot supply; learning is recollection. *Assessment:* even if sound, it establishes **pre-existence only** - which is why Plato must pair it with the cyclical argument to close the post-mortem direction.

3. Affinity. The composite, visible and changing perishes; the non-composite, invisible and stable does not; the soul resembles the second. *Assessment:* Plato presents this as likeness, not proof; resemblance to the imperishable does not entail imperishability, and simplicity is assumed.

4. The Form of Life. What essentially brings a Form cannot admit its opposite: snow cannot admit heat, and soul, essentially bringing Life, cannot admit death. *Assessment:* the inference from "cannot admit death" to "cannot cease" needs a bridge - fire does not become cold, but fire goes out.

The internal objection. Simmias: the soul is an attunement (*harmonia*) of bodily elements and perishes with the instrument. Plato replies twice: an attunement cannot pre-exist its instrument, whereas recollection shows the soul did; and the soul **rules** the body, opposing appetite, which no attunement does.

The external critique. Kant's paralogism: the unity of apperception is a formal condition of thought, not knowledge of a persisting substance. Immortality survives only as a postulate of practical reason.

Verdict. Taken singly the arguments establish at most pre-existence and a resemblance to the indestructible; taken together they display a coherent picture whose weakest joint is the step from essential predication to indestructibility.

Marks rationale. Four separate assessments, the internal objection with Plato's twofold reply, a named external critic, and a graded verdict rather than a blanket rejection.

Timing skeleton (20 minutes). 3 min plan · 10 min four arguments with assessments · 3 min Simmias and reply · 2 min Kant · 2 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Summarising the four as one proof; omitting Simmias; treating Kant as denying the soul's existence.

Solved PYQ 13 - 2023 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Examine the significance of the concept of rebirth in the theory of Karma.

Demand decoding. A **function** question. Describing rebirth answers a different stem; the marks are in what rebirth does *for* karma theory.

Model answer (≈250 words). The problem rebirth solves. Karma claims that every morally weighted act matures into its result. But many acts plainly do not mature within a lifetime: the good suffer, the cruel prosper, and infants suffer before they can have acted. Three exits are available - abandon the exceptionless claim; concentrate settlement into one post-mortem judgement, which is the Semitic route; or **widen the field of maturation across many lives**. Rebirth is the third exit, and that is its significance.

What it thereby contributes. (i) It preserves an **exceptionless** moral law against the evidence, without appeal to a divine reason for each allocation. (ii) It explains **initial inequality**: the conditions of birth are consequences rather than impositions. (iii) It secures **beginninglessness** (*anādī*), so no "first fault" must be explained, as it must in a Fall narrative. (iv) It makes **liberation intelligible** by supplying something to be liberated *from*.

The mechanism, briefly. Latent dispositions (*saṃskāra/vāsanā*) persist; the gross body is discarded (*Gītā* 2.22); the subtle body or, in Buddhism, causal conditioning determines the next embodiment. *Gītā* 9.21 shows even heaven is within the series.

The costs. The regress explains each birth by an earlier one and never the series as a whole; there is no past-life memory; and the doctrine risks reading present suffering as evidence of past fault. **Replies:** beginninglessness is a positive doctrine, not an oversight; memory is not the criterion of continuity; explanation licenses no social blame.

Verdict. Rebirth is not an ornament on karma theory but its enabling condition - the widened temporal field without which the law would have to be abandoned or heavily qualified.

Marks rationale. The fit-problem stated first, three rival exits named, four contributions listed, mechanism kept subordinate, and costs answered without over-claiming.

Timing skeleton (15 minutes). 2 min plan · 4 min fit-problem and exits · 4 min contributions · 2 min mechanism · 2 min costs · 1 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Narrating rebirth; omitting the Semitic alternative that shows why the Indian exit is a choice; claiming rebirth solves the problem of evil outright.

Solved PYQ 14 - 2024 Q5(c), 10 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Discuss the concept of liberation (*Apavarga*) according to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika.

Demand decoding. A **named term**. Fix it against the parity bench in the opening lines, then derive it from the school's own metaphysics. The single decisive detail is the absence of consciousness.

Model answer (≈150 words). The chain. Nyāya traces suffering back through birth, activity and defect to **false knowledge**. Because the chain is causal, cutting it at the root unwinds everything downstream: true knowledge of the categories and of the self removes false knowledge; without false knowledge there is no defect, without defect no binding activity, without activity no rebirth, and without rebirth no suffering.

The terminus. *Apavarga* is the **absolute cessation of pain** together with the qualities that sustain embodied experience. Because Nyāya treats consciousness as an **adventitious** quality - arising only when the self is conjoined with mind, senses and body - the released self exists **without consciousness, pleasure or bliss**.

Objection and reply. Such a state seems indistinguishable from insentience, and undesirable. The reply is that the school offers not a reward but the end of a defect: its value is negative and complete, since no experience of any kind can arise again.

Placement. It is therefore unlike Advaitic self-luminous release, Viśiṣṭādvaitic communion and Jain omniscient perfection.

Marks rationale. The causal chain reconstructed, the adventitious-consciousness doctrine named as the reason for the negative terminus, the objection met, and the comparative placement supplied.

Timing skeleton (10 minutes). 1 min plan · 3 min chain · 3 min terminus · 2 min objection · 1 min placement.

Penalties to avoid. Calling *apavarga* blissful; omitting the adventitious-consciousness doctrine; blending the Nyāya chain with the Buddhist one.

Solved PYQ 15 - 2024 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Is it necessary to adhere to the notions of immortality of soul and rebirth in order to have a robust conception of liberation? Give reasons and justifications for your answer.

Demand decoding. A **compound modal** question: two notions, one conception, and an explicit demand for reasons. The answer must define "robust" before deciding whether the notions are required.

Model answer (≈300 words). Fixing the terms. A conception of liberation is *robust* if it identifies (i) what bondage is, (ii) what is liberated, (iii) what the terminus is, and (iv) why the terminus is final. The question is whether (ii) requires an immortal soul and whether bondage requires rebirth.

The substantialist case for "yes". Advaita, Viśiṣṭādvaita, Nyāya and Jainism all answer affirmatively. Liberation presupposes bondage-across-lives, and something that is liberated. Nyāya's *apavarga* is the release of an eternal self-substance; Jain perfection is the manifestation of an eternal soul's infinitudes; Viśiṣṭādvaita's communion presupposes an eternal individual. Without a continuant, they argue, "liberation" has no subject and "bondage" no history.

The counter-case. Buddhism satisfies all four robustness conditions **without** an immortal soul: bondage is craving and ignorance; what is liberated is a conditioned stream, not an owner; the terminus is the extinguishing of craving (*nirvāṇa*); and finality is secured because the conditions for renewed becoming have ceased. Sāṃkhya presses from the other side: by kārikās 62-63 **no puruṣa is bound, released or transmigrating** - it is *prakṛti* who binds and releases herself - so even a school with an eternal consciousness denies that *it* is what undergoes liberation.

What each notion actually supplies. Rebirth supplies the *history* that makes bondage more than a present episode, and immortality supplies a *subject*. Buddhism replaces the subject with a stream while retaining the history; and no school dispenses with the history altogether.

Objection and reply. If nothing persists, is liberation anyone's? The Buddhist reply grounds ownership in causal descent; critics answer that descent is thinner than ownership. The pressure is real and should be conceded.

Verdict. Rebirth, or some equivalent account of bondage-history, is effectively necessary for robustness. Immortality of a **substantial** soul is not: what is necessary is a continuity-bearer, and whether that bearer is a substance remains the live dispute.

Marks rationale. "Robust" defined before use; the two notions separated and answered differently; two counter-cases rather than one; the objection conceded; and a two-part verdict.

Timing skeleton (20 minutes). 3 min plan · 3 min defining robustness · 5 min substantialist case · 5 min counter-cases · 2 min objection · 2 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Giving one verdict for both notions; omitting the Sāṃkhya kārikās; leaving "robust" undefined.

Solved PYQ 16 - 2025 Q5(d), 10 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Discuss the nature of embodied liberation (jīvanmukti) with reference to Advaita Vedānta.

Demand decoding. A **named doctrine within a named school**. The whole answer turns on why liberation can be present while a body continues - which requires the karma distinction.

Model answer (≈150 words). The claim. In Advaita, release (*mokṣa*) is the removal of ignorance (*avidyā*), not the production of a new state. Since ignorance is destroyed the moment liberating knowledge arises, the knower of Brahman is free **now**: *jīvanmukti* is liberation while embodied life continues.

Why the body remains. Knowledge destroys stored (*sañcita*) and future (*āgāmi*) karma, but **already-fructifying karma (prārabdha)** has begun to ripen and runs its course. The canonical image is the **potter's wheel**, which continues to spin after the potter's hand is withdrawn. At its exhaustion the body falls, and this is *videhamukti*.

Objection and reply. If ignorance is destroyed, why does empirical activity continue? Advaita distinguishes destroyed bondage from residual embodied momentum, locating the residue in the body-mind complex rather than in the knower; critics regard this as reintroducing a trace of ignorance.

Significance. Liberation is thus a cognitive-existential transformation, not a post-mortem reward - freedom is present realisation, not a future place.

Marks rationale. The removal model stated as the ground of present freedom, the karma distinction delivered exactly, the objection met, and a significance line that converts doctrine into evaluation.

Timing skeleton (10 minutes). 1 min plan · 3 min the claim · 3 min the karma distinction · 2 min objection · 1 min significance.

Penalties to avoid. Saying knowledge destroys fructifying karma; treating *jīvanmukti* as partial liberation; omitting *videhamukti*.

Solved PYQ 17 - 2025 Q7(c), 15 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Is the concept of immortality of soul a necessary condition for Rebirth? Discuss with reference to the Bhagavad Gītā.

Demand decoding. A modal question **plus** a named text. Verse fidelity is compulsory: generic Vedānta will not satisfy "with reference to the *Bhagavad Gītā*".

Model answer (≈250 words). The Gītā's own position. The text presupposes a deathless self and derives rebirth from it. *Gītā* 2.23 states that weapons do not cut it, fire does not burn it, water does not wet it and wind does not wither it. 2.22 gives the canonical image: as worn-out garments are discarded for new ones, so the embodied self lays aside worn-out bodies and enters others. 9.21 completes the picture by showing that even heaven is a stage *inside* the wandering-on, since the meritorious return when merit is exhausted. On the *Gītā*'s own terms, therefore, immortality is not merely compatible with rebirth: it is the premise from which rebirth follows.

But is it necessary? A premise sufficient for a conclusion need not be necessary for it. Buddhism affirms re-becoming (*punarbhava*) while denying a permanent self (*anātman*): impermanence of all conditioned factors, non-selfhood of the aggregates, and conditioning by craving and karmic formations together yield continuity **without an owner** - flame lit from flame, milk becoming curd, neither the same nor wholly other. Sāṃkhya adds a second pressure from within the substantialist camp: by kārikās 62-63 it is *prakṛti*, not *puruṣa*, who binds, transmigrates and releases herself.

Objection and reply. Without a persisting self, who receives the fruit? Responsibility rests on causal descent rather than substantial identity - a reply that preserves the doctrine while leaving the ownership worry live.

Verdict. Within the *Gītā*'s metaphysics, immortality is the ground of rebirth. Across the traditions it is **sufficient but not necessary**: what rebirth requires is a continuity-bearer, and the *Gītā* simply takes that bearer to be a deathless self.

Marks rationale. Text-fidelity discharged with three verses used for three distinct purposes, then the modal question answered across traditions, with a second counter-pressure and a conclusion that respects both demands.

Timing skeleton (15 minutes). 2 min plan · 5 min *Gītā* verses · 4 min Buddhist counter-case · 2 min Sāṃkhya pressure · 2 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Answering without *Gītā* verses; quoting invented English translations; giving the Buddhist case without first honouring the named text.

Original Mains practice with model solutions - six questions

These are original UPSC-style questions written against this owner. Word bands: **10 marks ≈ 150 words · 15 marks ≈ 250 words · 20 marks ≈ 300 words.**

Original Mains 1 - 10 marks

Question: Distinguish between rebirth and reincarnation, and explain why the distinction matters for a comparative account of Indian soteriology.

Model answer (≈150 words). The distinction. *Reincarnation* - literally re-enfleshing - presupposes a **substantial soul** that re-enters a new body. *Rebirth* is the wider and more neutral term for renewed becoming within a beginningless series, and it commits the user to a *continuity-bearer* without specifying that the bearer is a substance.

Why it matters. (i) It fixes school-attribution: reincarnation is apt for Vedānta, Nyāya and Jainism, and **incorrect for Buddhism**, whose re-becoming (*punarbhava*) has no transmigrating self. (ii) It prevents a false consensus: writing "all Indian schools accept reincarnation" silently imports a substance-metaphysics into a school that denies it. (iii) It shapes the modal verdict on necessity questions, since the counter-example only exists once the wider term is available. (iv) Sanskrit registers the range - *punarjanma*, *punarāvṛtti*, *punarbhava*, *saṃsāra* - so the distinction is lexical as well as doctrinal.

Conclusion. The distinction is not terminological fastidiousness: it is what keeps a comparative account from begging the central metaphysical question.

Original Mains 2 - 10 marks

Question: "Liberation is a family-resemblance term, not the name of a single state." Examine this claim with reference to at least four Indian schools.

Model answer (≈150 words). The claim. One English word covers destinations that differ in what ends, what remains and whether consciousness is present.

Four schools. *Advaita*: ignorance ends, Brahman alone remains, and awareness is self-luminous - liberation as **identity**. *Viśiṣṭādvaita*: karmic bondage ends, the eternal individual soul remains in communion with God - liberation as **communion**, never absorption. *Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika*: pain and the qualities sustaining experience end, the self-substance remains **without consciousness** - liberation as **cessation**. *Sāṃkhya-Yoga*: non-discrimination ends, *puruṣa* stands alone, conscious but contentless - liberation as **isolation**. Add Jainism, where karmic matter ends and a **perfected omniscient individual** remains, and Buddhism, where craving ends and no self is asserted at all.

Assessment. These are not degrees of one state; identity and communion are mutually exclusive, and cessation excludes the very awareness that identity requires.

Conclusion. The shared vocabulary conceals incompatible destinations, and the first task in any liberation answer is to say which one is meant.

Original Mains 3 - 15 marks

Question: Examine the claim that personal identity, rather than immortality, is the real philosophical issue in the survival debate. Illustrate with both Western and Indian material.

Model answer (≈250 words). The claim. Whether something survives is less contested than *what would make the survivor me*. Immortality answers a question about duration; identity answers a question about sameness, and the second is prior.

The criteria. Four rivals: bodily continuity, psychological or memory continuity, soul-substance, and causal continuity. The first two tell us how identity is recognised; the last two propose what constitutes it. Memory cannot define identity, since it presupposes it and is fallible and branchable.

Western illustration. Resurrection faces the **gap problem** and the **re-assembly objection**. Aquinas secures continuity by treating the rational soul as the *form* of the body; van Inwagen has God preserve the body or a core of it; Hick's **replica theory** holds that a unique psychophysical duplicate with continuous memory and character, appearing in another space, is the same person for every purpose that matters. The **duplication objection** answers that if God can make one replica he can make two, and identity is one-to-one - so the criterion tracks similarity.

Indian illustration. Vedānta and Nyāya answer with a substance; Jainism with an eternal individual soul; Sāṃkhya distinctively denies that the witness migrates at all (*Sāṃkhya-kārikā* 62-63); and Buddhism replaces the owner with a causal stream, defending responsibility by **causal descent** - "neither the same nor wholly other". The **memory objection** to rebirth is the mirror-image of the duplication objection to resurrection.

Assessment. Both traditions can secure duration and struggle to secure sameness, which is precisely the claim under examination.

Conclusion. Immortality is the headline; identity is the argument - and every serious position in this clause is finally a choice of continuity-bearer.

Original Mains 4 - 15 marks

Question: "Karma explains the distribution of suffering, but the explanation carries a moral cost." Discuss with reference to the theistic and non-theistic schools.

Model answer (≈250 words). The explanatory claim. Karma answers a question theism finds hard: not why suffering exists, but why *this* person suffers. Act and its unseen potency (*adṛṣṭa/apūrva*) mature as stored, fructifying and future karma within a beginningless series, so present condition is consequence rather than allocation.

The two administrations. In Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā the law is **self-regulating**: no judge is required, and the moral order is a basic feature of how things work. In Nyāya and the theistic Vedāntas God is the **superintendent** (*karmādhyaṅkṣa*) who ratifies and dispenses desert rather than authoring it. The fork matters: the first purchases economy at the price of a law without a legislator; the second retains a personal God at the price of subordinating him to a law he did not make.

The moral cost. Because present suffering is read as the maturation of past action, the doctrine can be turned into an inference from suffering to fault. That inference is (i) epistemically unwarranted, since no one has access to the ledger, and (ii) practically corrosive, since it converts a metaphysical explanation into a social verdict.

The replies. The traditions themselves block the inference: explanatory karma does not license social judgement, and the duty of compassion and relief is untouched by any account of desert. Beginninglessness also removes the "original fault" framing that most easily supports blame.

Assessment. The explanatory gain is real and distinctive; the cost is not intrinsic to the doctrine but is easily produced by careless use.

Conclusion. Karma should be presented as an account of *why the world is orderly*, never as an instrument for reading a sufferer's past.

Original Mains 5 - 20 marks

Question: Critically compare the Semitic doctrine of resurrection with the Indian doctrine of rebirth, and assess whether either succeeds in securing the identity of the person who survives.

Model answer (≈300 words). Frame. These are not variants of one idea. They differ in number of lives, mechanism, judge, telos, identity-bearer, treatment of the body and direction of time. Cullmann (1955) argues that Greek immortality of the soul and Hebrew resurrection of the dead are **opposed** rather than complementary - the first releases the soul from the body, the second treats the person as a psychosomatic unity that only a divine act can restore.

The grid. Resurrection: one earthly life; a divine act at the end of history; God as judge; restored embodied life in communion; the body essential, a "spiritual body" still a body; linear time. Rebirth: a beginningless series; karma maturing through the wandering-on; the karmic law itself, with God ratifying in Nyāya and Rāmānuja; **exit** from the series as telos; the body discarded like clothing (*Gītā* 2.22) while the subtle body carries dispositions; cyclical time with a linear exit.

Identity under resurrection. Two problems: the **gap** between death and raising, and the **re-assembly** objection where matter is shared between bodies. Three replies: Aquinas (the rational soul as form secures continuity); van Inwagen (God preserves the body or a core, leaving a simulacrum); Hick (a unique psychophysical replica with memory and character *is* the person). The **duplication objection** is decisive against the third as stated: if one replica, why not two?

Identity under rebirth. The **memory objection**: nothing of prior lives is recalled. The reply distinguishes episodic memory from metaphysical continuity and appeals to latent dispositions - coherent, but evidentially empty. Buddhism avoids the problem by abandoning strict identity for causal descent, at the cost of the ownership worry.

Assessment. Neither secures identity, but for opposite reasons: resurrection must show that a re-constituted person is numerically the same; rebirth must show that a being with no memory of me is me.

Conclusion. They answer different questions - how an essentially embodied person can survive, and how moral desert can be discharged when one life is too short - and both leave the identity question open.

Original Mains 6 - 20 marks

Question: "Every Indian conception of liberation is determined by its account of bondage." Examine this thesis across the major schools, and state what follows for the means of liberation.

Model answer (≈300 words). Thesis. The terminus is fixed by the diagnosis. Tell me what a school takes bondage to be, and its conception of release - and its permitted means - follow.

School by school. *Advaita*: bondage is **ignorance** (*avidyā*), so release is the removal of an error; individuality is sublated, and only **knowledge** can remove it; liberation while living (*jīvanmukti*) is possible because nothing must be acquired, the body continuing on already-fructifying karma. *Viśiṣṭādvaita*: bondage is **karma and dependence**, so release is an attained relation - communion and service - reached by knowledge, devotion (*dhruvānusr̥ti*) and self-surrender (*prapatti*), with grace decisive. *Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika*: bondage is the conjunction that generates pain, traced back to **false knowledge**, so release is the cessation of pain *and* of the qualities sustaining experience, reached by true knowledge of the categories. *Sāṃkhya-Yoga*: bondage is **non-discrimination** (*aviveka*), not a real bond, so release is discriminative discernment (*viveka-khyāti*) and the terminus is contentless aloneness; kārikās 62-63 add that strictly no *puruṣa* was ever bound. *Jainism*: bondage is **quasi-material karmic matter** attracted by passion, so release requires stoppage (*saṃvara*) and shedding (*nirjarā*) - an ethics of restraint and austerity rather than of knowledge alone. *Buddhism*: bondage is **craving and ignorance**, so release is their extinguishing, reached by the path, with no self to be freed.

What follows for the means. The **production versus removal** fork governs everything: if release is a result to be produced, action can produce it (*Mīmāṃsā*); if it is the removal of an error, only knowledge removes it (*Śaṅkara*); if it is an attained relation, devotion and grace are intelligible as direct means (*Rāmānuja*). Action qualifies, devotion receives, knowledge removes.

Qualification. The thesis is strong but not absolute: Jainism's material diagnosis makes practice, not cognition, the primary means, showing that the diagnosis fixes the *kind* of means as much as the terminus.

Conclusion. Conceptions of liberation are not free-standing ideals; they are the exact inverse of each school's account of what has gone wrong.